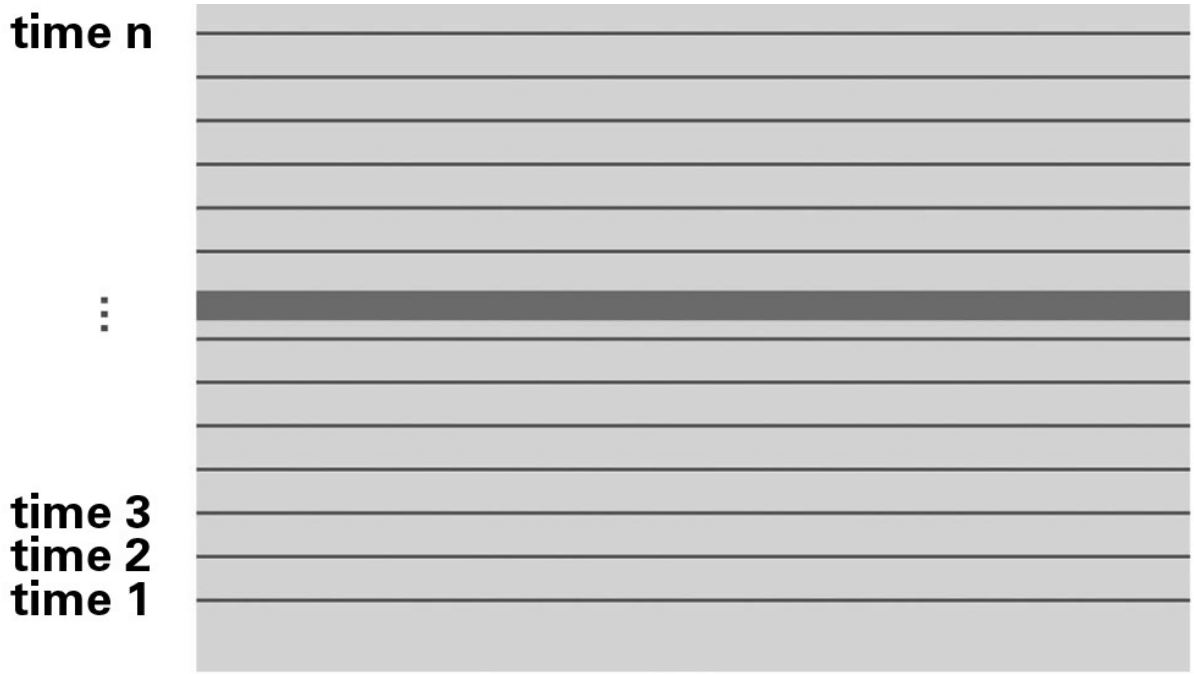


But the second diagram provides a better representation of the temporal structure of the world, and in it there is nothing that resembles a present. There is no present. So what is real *now*?

Twentieth-century physics shows, in a way that seems unequivocal to me, that our world is not described well by presentism: an objective global present does not exist. The most we can speak of is a present relative to a moving observer. But then, what is real for me is different from that which is real for you, despite the fact that we would like to use the expression "real"—in an objective sense—as much as possible. Therefore, the world should not be thought of as a succession of presents.[59]

What alternatives do we have?

Philosophers call "eternalism" the idea that flow and change are illusory: present, past, and future are all equally real and equally existent. Eternalism is the idea that the whole of spacetime, as outlined in the above diagrams, exists all together in its entirety without anything changing. Nothing really flows.[60]

Those who defend this way of thinking about reality—eternalism—frequently cite Einstein, who in a famous letter writes:

> People like us who believe in physics, know that the distinction between past, present and future is only a stubbornly persistent illusion.[61]

This idea has come to be called the "block universe": the idea that it is necessary to think of the history of the universe as a single block, all equally real, and that the passage from one moment of time to the next is illusory.